



CHANGE YOU CAN RELY ON

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As a bochur in yeshiva, I used to go on mivtzoim with another bochur who, in addition to putting on tefillin, would squeeze money for tzedakah out of the people he met. He explained that it's a mivtzah of the Rebbe, and it's just as important to encourage our fellow Jews in this mivtzah as in any other, even when it's hard for them. This is a worthwhile perspective to keep in mind when raising funds from our community members.

That being said, what are shluchim doing in the area of fundraising during these tough economic times?

REACH OUT TO THE MIDDLE CLASS

One valuable key is to reach out to the middle class, because many of the wealthy donors that fundraisers used to rely on are wealthy no more.

For example, instead of choosing one very wealthy honoree for our annual dinner this year, we made an event in December and honored eight people before Chanukah. We are spreading the honor around to alleviate the pressure of getting a single large donor, thus allowing more people to participate and be involved at a much lower price. It was more of a community event than your typical dinner, with a separate program for kids while the adults attended a dessert reception. This took place on a Sunday afternoon during the hours between lunch and dinner. It is much less expensive, and people can place ads in the journal at a lower dollar amount—as little as \$36.

E-CHARITYBOX.COM

Another useful tool we have implemented in our Chabad House is echaritybox.com. It's an electronic charity box which people can download on their iPhones and BlackBerrys. Community members can contribute regularly, and when the box is "full," it empties out to the Chabad House account. This makes the mitzvah of giving tzedakah simple and easy to do on a daily basis.

TRAIN PEOPLE TO GIVE

Not everyone "knows" how to practice philanthropy, especially those who

haven't been raised with money. As a rabbi, you can train those people by starting off small and consistent. I've created a system of monthly donations which cover 20-30% of my annual budget. Over time, you get enough people giving small dollars and it adds up!

You will find that the people who give

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on a regular basis begin to feel good about it and get used to making a commitment. They serve as the foundation for the community and they know it. Then, their commitment grows. I have regular supporters who started very small, and in subsequent years, I've asked them to increase. This form of fundraising is particularly necessary in today's economy.

PEOPLE WHO CAN NO LONGER GIVE WHAT THEY USED TO

What happens when your usual donors no longer have what they used to? The first thing is to be sympathetic because today, people are really hurting. We weren't sent on shlichus to be fundraisers, even though it may be part of the job. We have to be there for people. A person who is no longer in a position to give is in pain, and we need to nurture their emotional needs in their challenging times. They will be grateful and will be there for you when things turn

around for them.

Even when your usual donors are financially tight, you can give them the opportunity to give in other ways. Their personal services may prove to be a valuable resource. Have people volunteer and invest in sweat equity, as opposed to monetary equity.

CREATIVE SPENDING

In addition to all your creative fundraising tactics, an important point to remember is that you have to be creative about programming. We're used to spending a lot of money on making effective programs. But with a little creativity, you can accomplish more things with less money. Necessity gives birth to creativity.

Look at any program during the year and see how you can make a greater impact without spending so much. A big part is in empowering people in the community to do things at various levels of planning and execution so you don't have to use Chabad House funds to pay for services. That, itself, saves money so you need to raise less. 

המעשה הוא העיקר

- Talk to your community about the mitzvah of tzedakah during speeches and in private conversation.
- Be there for people who can no longer give what they used to.
- Set up an eCharityBox account and tell your community about it.